asset named Hayyan who worked in President Hafez al-Assad's Syrian Ba'ath Party regime. Vipul and Hayyan had earlier worked together in Lebanon. Hayyan had managed to enter the inner group of Ayatollah Mohammed Hussein Fadlallah, a Shia cleric and supposed supporter of the Hezbollah, a Lebanese militant organisation that arrived on the radar of the world's security agencies following the 1983 Beirut bombing in which hundreds of US and French soldiers had been killed. Vipul had been carrying out a limited operation in Beirut in 1983 when Hayyan introduced him to the religious preacher. Fadlallah told Vipul he could smell spies and if it was not for the painful experience of betrayal, he considered the profession the most important to protect a country.

'Even if it is not a pleasant work, it does make life pleasurable for the people of the country,' Vipul told Fadlallah. 'Spying is not just about betrayal and dualities, it is also about a love affair that gives colour to the superficial layer of security.'

Hezbollah was conceived during the successful Iranian revolution and spies believed it helped the radicalisation of Shias as well as militant activities in the neighbourhood with Khomeini as an idol. For Vipul, though, Fadlal-lah was a keyhole through which to peep into the affairs of the Middle East and carry out his operation quietly.

Now after almost two years since they had last met, the primary reason for Vipul to meet Hayyan against the backdrop of the Iran-Iraq war was simple—could he exploit Fadlallah's relationship with the Iranian leaders to get a foothold in the Iranian regime that was hostile towards India? For spies, it was no longer a secret that Hezbollah had been raised with Iranian